



SHASHI PAUL

“All Bollywood actresses do is give horny looks.”

The Brave One

Kangna Ranaut, 22

I am not in the business just to show my tits and ass,” says the no-nonsense 22-year-old from Manali-via Chandigarh boarding-Delhi theatre. “Bollywood actresses are sex objects. All they do is give horny looks. The men are like beefed-up aliens. Because our actors sing, dance, act and endorse, they behave like pop stars.” If Ranaut onscreen is brutally honest, Ranaut in real life is no less. Her tiny frame with its wiry hair has already been subjected to much movie abuse—from an alcoholic problem in *Gangster* to schizophrenia in *Woh Lamhe* to drug addiction in *Fashion*. Ranaut doesn’t just act, she launches her entire being into a role, researching it, living it 19 hours a day, even taking a month off to do yoga and be “normal” after she is done. “I prepare for every role like I am taking an exam,” she says, laughing wryly. “I work like a maniac.” She has to, for she’s set very high goals for herself. After her tortured other woman in *Life in a...Metro*, she rejected 50-60 similar scripts. “As actors we are at the receiving end. But you have to stick to your rules.” So far she’s managed working with Anurag Basu in *Gangster*, *Life in a...Metro* and the forthcoming *Kites* with Hrithik Roshan, Madhur Bhandarkar in *Fashion* and Mohit Suri in *Woh Lamhe* and *Raaz: The Mystery Continues*. And Suneel Darshan in the execrable *Shakalaka Boom Boom*, but let’s not go there. With her fierce energy, her impassioned belief in herself, her maturity beyond years (“I feel like a 40-year-old”), she has every reason to be enthusiastic about her future. And yes, she can laugh. Without it ending in tears. Or hysteria.

The Import

Asin, 23

She’s been working since 14. She’s moved cities twice already, from Kochi to Chennai to Mumbai. Her mother Celine has given up her medical career to manage the homefront. And her father Joseph Thottumkal (known to all as JT) has given up his business to become her manager. A-Sin, as in without sin, is an amalgam of Hindi and English, and for someone who moves so easily between Kamal Hassan and Aamir Khan, it is perhaps appropriate. Wowing the world as Kalpana in *Ghajini*, a part she had already played opposite Surya in the Tamil version, Asin is now the toast of tinseltown, currently wrapping up her second Hindi film opposite Ajay Devgan and Salman Khan (*London Dreams*, where she plays a rock chick), picking her next superstar to work with, shooting ads with the seven majors she endorses (from Mirinda to Tanishq) and absorbing the media’s desperate hunger for trivia. “I once had a television reporter analysing the contents of my lunch *dabba*,” she exclaims. Every day, she reads a new rumour about herself, but it doesn’t bother her. “I am what I am,” she says. What matters to her is the script, the role, the director, the banner and then the co-artiste. For someone who’s acted with every superstar in the south (“except for Rajni sir”), it’s an A for attitude.



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